A catalyst for change

Leading the American Dental Association toward a brighter future

Brett Kessler, DDS

As I begin my term as the 161st president of the American Dental Association (ADA), I am reminded of how much this profession has empowered me to live a fulfilling life and to inspire others to do the same.

The heart of the dental profession, after all, is the smile—a beacon of happiness and health. This is why I love the work I do—seeing patients' joy, comfort, and confidence shine through their smiles.

Through this lens, I see the incredible potential we, as dental care professionals, have to make a difference, not only within our profession but also for our colleagues, patients, and communities.

My unconventional journey in dentistry has shaped personal core values that now drive my mission to create positive change. These values form the foundation of my vision for the ADA, built on 3 pillars: promoting wellness, fostering a culture of respect, and integrating oral health within overall health.

WELLNESS: LIVING OUR BEST LIVES

My commitment to living well came after I hit rock bottom. I entered dental school with a substance abuse problem, which worsened by the time I graduated. During my general practice residency, a presentation from an addiction medicine specialist planted a seed that eventually led me to make a call to the Michigan Dental Association's wellness program for help.

That call saved my life. It was the moment I chose recovery and began the journey to living my best life possible, for myself and for the people I love and serve.

Addiction is a disease of the brain, one that requires the same level of care, attention, and compassion as any other chronic illness. Yet so many, including my peers in dentistry, face it silently, overwhelmed by stigma and the demands of career and daily life. That was my reality until I finally acknowledged the severity of my situation and sought help.

I was fortunate to have a dental community that offered the resources and support I needed to overcome my challenges. Now, I am committed to ensuring that the same lifelines are available to all dentists who may have similar struggles so they never have to face them alone.

Dentistry and life can be hard, and many of our colleagues are suffering. An ADA survey[1] from April 2023 found that more than 40% of dentists reported feeling defeated or wanting to quit at least once a month, with younger dentists particularly affected. More than 90% reported career-related stress, often linked to low insurance reimbursements and high student debt. In a separate survey, data showed anxiety rates among dentists have tripled since 2003, with younger dentists experiencing higher levels of stress and depression.[2]

I believe that to be at our best we must prioritize well-being in 5 dimensions: physical, mental, emotional, spiritual, and social. Just as it is important to reach out to others if you are struggling with addiction, mental health issues, or emotional challenges, there are daily habits that we can do in each of these dimensions to keep us strong.

I want all members to know that they can count on the ADA, along with their state and local societies, as a support system they can access without shame. Yet less than one-half of dentists are aware of state dentist well-being programs available through their dental associations.[2]

The ADA offers a wide array of resources at ADA.org/wellness, including tools for stress management, work-life balance, physical activity, and mental health awareness.[3]

The ADA's Dentist Health and Wellness Program, along with state dentist well-being programs, are all available to provide support. Members can connect with their state program director by contacting dentalpractice@ada.org or downloading the ADA Dentist Well-Being Program Directory[4] for more information.

Guest editorials represent the opinions of the authors and not necessarily those of the American Dental Association.

We are raising awareness of these resources through the ADA's Wellness Ambassador Program,[5] which consists of volunteer dentists from various districts and practice modalities helping peers find the support they need, and they are truly making a difference in our community.

We also offer ADA members free access to the Mayo Clinic's Well-Being Index.[6] This easy-to-use self-assessment tool (available at ADA.org/resources/practice/wellness/well-being-index) lets members quickly check in on their physical and mental health and receive personalized resources.

Beyond the ADA's existing resources, I would like to spotlight the Federation of State Physician Health Programs, a national nonprofit that encourages state dental boards to use best practices to help colleagues who may be facing mental health challenges or substance use disorders.[7] The ADA's Council on Dental Practice and the Dental Team Wellness Advisory Committee have teamed up with the Federation of State Physician Health Programs to promote clinician well-being. Twenty-nine Physician Health Programs already support dentists with confidentiality and dignity. I encourage members to explore whether their state offers similar resources by visiting fsphp.org.

The ADA is also supporting efforts to destigmatize intrusive questions about mental health that appear on state licensure and credentialing applications. These may deter colleagues from seeking help. We are advocating to the American Association of Dental Boards to make these changes. Our Association has developed the toolkit Reducing Barriers to Mental Health Care to address this issue, and it is available at ADA.org/LicensureToolkit.[8]

Our community's support network is strong and ready to help members in their mental health journeys. Health is our most valuable asset, and we must take care of ourselves.

FOSTERING A CULTURE OF RESPECT AND INCLUSION

As former chair of the Diversity and Inclusion Committee, I learned firsthand that many of our colleagues do not feel welcome at the ADA. We must embrace all of our colleagues and make them feel included, at all levels of the tripartite.

I want to continue to foster an environment in which everyone feels supported, respected, and heard; diversity is celebrated; and collaboration is encouraged.

With a growing number of people entering the profession representing many diverse backgrounds and demographics, along with a workforce that is increasingly younger and moving away from solo practice,[9] it is imperative for the ADA to embrace this diversity as a reflection of our core values. Imagine the progress we could make if we reinforced belonging and helped people of all backgrounds see themselves among the leaders who are shaping dentistry's future.

The ADA remains committed to ensuring equitable opportunities for all, including through our governance. By adopting a strategic forecasting model, our decision-making processes are now inclusive of more diverse voices from across the profession.

Ongoing programs like the Institute for Diversity in Leadership[10] and the Champions Network[11] also help us build an ecosystem of collaboration, connection, and mutual respect to honor the diversity that enriches dentistry.

ELEVATING ORAL HEALTH IN PRIMARY CARE

As greater integration between primary care and oral health care takes center stage, dentists have a renewed opportunity to take a major stand for both oral and overall health.

The work of reconnecting the mouth to the body will be a priority during my presidency, focusing on bridging the dental and medical communities to drive collaborative care.

To achieve this, we must rethink the dental care model, which separates dental and medical care despite clear evidence linking poor oral health with systemic health issues. Dentistry can play a vital role in primary care via expanding screening to include DNA and bacterial testing and diabetes testing, as well as vaccine administration.

Most patients visit dentists for preventative care, whereas they see physicians when symptoms arise. Imagine a model in which dentists identify risks for chronic diseases early on during routine visits and guide patients toward healthier lifestyles through proactive interventions like motivational interviewing—practices that are already gaining traction in various settings.

The growing body of scientific evidence supporting the oral-systemic connection compels us to advocate for expansion of benefits to better serve patients. Consider this: a patient with degenerative joint disease in the hip can receive a titanium replacement through their medical benefits yet cannot access the finest treatments dentistry has to offer, like a dental implant to replace a missing

tooth. If we applied the dental benefit model to medicine, patients needing hip replacements would only get crutches, the equivalent to offering a flipper instead of a dental implant.

Why do we accept this? Why is walking more important than mastication? A dentition that is healthy, functional, and esthetic is essential to overall health.

This is where the power of advocacy comes in. One of my proudest achievements as president of the Colorado Dental Association was helping develop a dental benefit for the Medicaid program for adults in Colorado, giving 300,000 people access to a dental home they did not have before.[12] This program remains one of the best in the country and stands as a testament to what is possible on a broader scale.

Nationally, the ADA is at the forefront of dental benefits reform ensuring that public and private programs enable patients to access quality oral health care as part of essential health care.[13] The ADA's Council on Government Affairs is actively lobbying for comprehensive adult dental Medicaid benefits federally and improved access for pregnant women, young children, and people with disabilities at the state level. Our support extends to vital legislation like the Action for Dental Health Act of 2023, which aims to reduce disparities by providing dental homes to underserved populations and reducing emergency department visits through increased access to holistic, preventative oral health care.

Building on these efforts, the ADA continues to collaborate with multiple stakeholders to improve access to care for vulnerable seniors. For instance, we are actively engaging with the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services to advocate for the clarification and expansion of the definition of Medicare's medically necessary dental benefits.

The ADA also is championing broader reforms within the private dental insurance sector. We are actively promoting transparency in private dental plan premiums through Dental Loss Ratio legislation, aligning more with medical industry standards, and having successfully advocated for state laws outlawing noncovered services provisions; our efforts continue in states that have not yet passed such laws.

Let us be the change makers who lead the charge, the advocates who champion public health, and the colleagues who uplift one another.

The ADA's commitment to public health is further shown through its access-to-care programs. More than 7 million children have received oral health care services through the ADA Foundation's flagship Give Kids A Smile program.[14] Building on this success, we are exploring ways to improve access for other vulnerable groups, including older adults and veterans, through initiatives like Give Veterans A Smile.[15]

Oral health is essential to overall health, and now is the time to elevate oral health care to its rightful place in the health care system. By leading this change, we can significantly improve health outcomes for everyone, leading to healthier, happier communities.

CONCLUSION

The ADA is well positioned to keep creating meaningful change. In addition to our patients and communities, our own network of colleagues can benefit from the power we all share as advocates, thought leaders, and care providers to elevate dentistry and improve the lives of others.

We have the power to shape the future we want to see for our profession, one in which every dentist lives their best life and every patient receives the comprehensive care they deserve.

Let us be the change makers who lead the charge, the advocates who champion public health, and the colleagues who uplift one another. It is the best way for all of us to shine. ■

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.adaj.2024.08.006

Copyright © 2024 American Dental Association. All rights are reserved, including those for text and data mining, AI training, and similar technologies.

DISCLOSURE

Dr. Kessler did not report any disclosures.

Dr. Kessler is the president, American Dental Association, Chicago, IL.
Address correspondence to Dr. Kessler, American Dental Association, 211 E Chicago Ave, Chicago, IL 60611, email kesslerb@ada.org.

1. ADA communications trend report: 2023. American Dental Association. Accessed August 2, 2024. https://www.ada.org/-/media/project/ada-organization/ada/ada-org/files/about/press-releases/2023_trend_report_-_8-9-23.pdf

2. Solana K. Survey: younger dentists report higher level of stress, emotional health concerns. *ADA News*. February 7, 2022. Accessed August 2, 2024. https://adanews.ada.org/new-dentist/2022/february/survey-younger-dentist-report-higher-level-of-stress-emotional-health-concerns

3. Wellness resources. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/resources/practice/wellness

4. Dentist well-being program directory. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/-/media/project/ada-organization/ada/ada-org/files/resources/practice/health-and-wellness/ada_org_state_well_being_program_directory.pdf

5. ADA Wellness Ambassador Program. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/resources/practice/wellness/ada-wellness-ambassador-program

6. Well-Being Index. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. http://www.ADA.org/resources/practice/wellness/well-being-index

7. State programs. Federation of State Physician Health Programs. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.fsphp.org/state-programs

8. Licensure toolkit. American Dental Association. http://www.ADA.org/LicensureToolkit

9. Solana K. HPI: Changes in dentist demographics, practice modalities accelerating. *ADA News*. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://adanews.ada.org/ada-news/2022/march/hpi-changes-in-dentist-demographics-practice-modalities-accelerating

10. ADA Institute for Diversity in Leadership. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/resources/careers/ada-institute-for-diversity-in-leadership

11. Champions Network. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/about/principles/diversity-and-inclusion/champions-network

12. Take 5: making Colorado healthier through access to a dentist. Colorado Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://cdaonline.org/take5

13. ADA advocacy. American Dental Association. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.ada.org/advocacy

14. Give Kids A Smile. ADA Foundation. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.adafoundation.org/give-kids-a-smile

15. Give Veterans A Smile. ADA Foundation. Accessed August 1, 2024. https://www.adafoundation.org/give-veterans-a-smile